THE PINK LEMON



Why Losing Isn't Always What It Looks Like

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Before We Start

I knew pink lemonade, of course, but I'd never seen a real lemon that was pink inside. There's a kind of Eureka lemon that grows with green and cream stripes on the outside and pale pink fruit on the inside. As the lemon ripens, much of the green can fade until it looks like the yellow lemon most of us expect. Cut it open, though, and the inside is still different. I liked that right away, probably more than a grown man needs to like a piece of fruit. The fruit was pink, but it was still a lemon, and it could be just as sour as the yellow kind. I've started to think about losing the same way. The name can be right and still tell us very little about what's inside.

Somebody says, "I lost," and our minds fill in the rest. We decide they weren't good enough or didn't work hard enough. Then we hand out the same advice: keep your head up, work harder, don't quit, use it as fuel. I've said versions of all of that myself, and so has every poster with a mountain on it. That advice has never fit every kind of loss. If you weren't good enough yet, the right move is to admit it, learn what you can, and keep working. More effort can't undo an injury or make another company's budget bigger, though, and effort can't change a call that was close to a coin flip. This isn't a book about making lemonade out of every bad thing that happens to you.

I understand why that saying has lasted, since there are times we can turn something sour into something useful, and I've done that in my own life. I no longer believe every loss is a secret gift, though, and I don't think pain has failed if it never turns into an inspiring story.

The pink lemon reminds me to look closely before deciding what a familiar label explains. The outside of the fruit doesn't tell a grower how well it will develop. A grower needs a closer look to know that, and a loss needs one too. We have to find out what happened before deciding what the result says about our choices or our future.

That's where this book started. I wasn't trying to invent a system for losing. I was trying to understand why ideas I'd carried most of my life no longer explained what I was seeing. I still believe in hard work and owning your part. My father taught me to get up when something goes wrong, because nobody else can live your life for you. Along the way, I stopped believing effort explains everything, because life gave me too many examples that didn't fit. My wife and I built a business that finally hit the monthly income we'd chased for years. That business didn't make us rich, but it gave us room to breathe, and that felt like a win.

About 45 days later, the business started coming apart. Several of our deals expired at the same time, and I had never put contracts in place for the others. I worked, worried, replayed conversations in my head, and looked for the mistake I'd missed. Some of what I found was useful: we had trusted some people more than we should have and left parts of the business unprotected. Other parts weren't going to be fixed by waking up earlier. That seems clear now, but it wasn't clear while I was in it.

Loss makes everything feel personal. A contract disappears, and somehow it becomes a statement about your talent. You don't make the team, and five minutes later your brain is asking whether you were ever good. A relationship ends, and you start reviewing your whole personality like it's due for an annual evaluation. You miss the shot, and suddenly the conversation in your head isn't about the shot anymore. I kept noticing how fast I jumped from what happened to

what I thought it meant. Sometimes I was right. More often I filled the gaps with the easiest story, which either blamed me for everything or let me off the hook.

Over time, I saw five patterns. In the first, someone beat you, and in the second, the margin was too close to read with much confidence. In the third, something was taken from you. In the fourth, you were playing the wrong game. In the fifth, you stopped taking part in a goal you still said you wanted. I call them The Five. They aren't science, and I'm not claiming I found five laws that explain every loss, since anybody selling five laws for your whole life usually has a workbook to go with them. The Five are a way to slow down and ask a question I used to skip: what actually happened?

If I don't know what happened, I don't know what I need to do. I might need to work harder, wait, grieve, change direction, forgive myself, or admit somebody was just better. Sometimes the answer is that I don't know yet. I used to be quicker to turn a loss into a lesson, and I'm less interested in doing that now. Some losses taught me things I'm grateful to know. Some only hurt. All of them belong in an honest book about losing. I want to start with baseball, because baseball was one of the first places I learned that effort matters but doesn't explain every result.

CHAPTER ONE

Not One

I loved baseball before I had much language for winning or losing. I grew up in Cleveland in the 1990s, which was a pretty good place and time to fall in love with the game. The Indians had a loaded roster, with guys like Kenny Lofton, Albert Belle, and Omar Vizquel, and Vizquel was my favorite. I went to games at Jacobs Field, back when the whole city had waited years for a championship and could talk itself pretty quickly into believing this might finally be the team. They made the World Series twice that decade and lost both times. I didn't go to Jacobs Field to watch them lose. I watched that on TV at my grandma's house with my dad and my uncles, and when the Indians lost, I went quiet and I got mad, in that order. As a kid, I couldn't explain why being that close made it hurt more. I only knew I wanted my team to win, and that I loved playing the game myself.

I watched games, played pickup ball with friends, and spent time in batting cages. On trips to the library with my dad, I'd grab baseball books along with whatever else caught my eye. *Nolan Ryan's Pitcher's Bible* is the one I remember, but it wasn't the only one. I liked the players, but I also wanted to understand how people got better. Why could one person throw harder than everybody else, and why was somebody else the better hitter? I don't think I'd have put it that way as a kid. I just wanted to know how people got good.

My dad had a fairly simple answer for what you did when you weren't good enough yet. You kept going. That was how he ap-

proached a lot of life. My dad was not running a feelings seminar. If something didn't work, you didn't sit around feeling sorry for yourself for very long, at least not where he could see you. You figured out what you needed to do and you tried again, because nobody was going to care enough about your situation to climb inside of it and fix your life for you. I still believe that.

Some losses really are that simple. You weren't prepared, or someone worked harder, or someone had built a skill you didn't have. Maybe you got distracted, let fear take over, or figured that wanting something would be enough. It happens. If I wasn't good enough or didn't prepare, I'd rather know than have somebody protect my feelings with a story that isn't true. Talking about failure shouldn't excuse any of us from looking honestly at our own part.

Baseball taught me some of that, and it also taught me that it wasn't the whole story. By the time I tried out for my high school team in eleventh grade, I felt ready, or at least I felt the version of ready I understood back then. I had played, practiced, and learned the game the way I knew it. Then I got around other kids who had been preparing for the same chance, and I started seeing details I didn't know were details. Some had better equipment. Some had played more organized baseball, with travel teams, coaching, and reps that neighborhood pickup games couldn't fully replace. None of that meant they didn't work, because they did. It didn't mean I'd done nothing either. We had reached the same tryout by different roads.

That may have been the first time I understood how many people can care deeply about the same opportunity. The roster only had so many spots, and wanting one wasn't going to make my preparation equal to everybody else's. Business works the same way, because many people want the same customer. Wanting something badly can feel special when you're alone with it. Then you walk into a room full of

people who want it just as badly, every one of them sure they're the main character, and you realize the wanting is only where it starts. Preparation, access, and the small details start to matter.

I made the team, and I remember being relieved and proud. I say that plainly because for years I judged the whole story by how it ended, and when the ending let me down, I treated the entire experience like a letdown. Then my arm started hurting in practice, and it kept getting worse over time. I never really got to see what my full potential in baseball might have been. That's the story, and I don't need to turn it into something bigger than it was. At the time, though, I was disappointed. Baseball had taken up so much room in my imagination that losing it meant I had to find other things to imagine.

My dad didn't say much about the injury. His answer to most things was to keep going, and this time there wasn't an obvious place to go. I grieved it, and eventually I moved on. What I didn't understand yet was why this loss felt different from the ones before it. If another kid struck me out, there was information in that. He might have had a better pitch, my timing might have been off, or I might have needed more work against that kind of delivery. An injury didn't hand me anything like that. I had spent a lot of my childhood learning that losing was evidence: you lose, so you go get better, practice more, and figure out what the winner did that you didn't. The injury ended the season without answering any of those questions. I had done enough to make the team, and I still didn't get to play the season I'd pictured. For a while I acted like the second fact canceled out the first.

As I've gotten older, I've noticed how fast we reach for an explanation. We say the winner worked harder and the loser didn't want it enough. We say the company that made it must have made better decisions, and the one that failed must have made bad ones. Sometimes

that's exactly right. A lot of the time we're reading the ending backward and building a story that makes the result look like it was always going to happen. We do it with winners too. After somebody succeeds, a morning routine or a mindset or a book on the shelf becomes the reason, even when nobody knows how much it mattered. Suddenly everybody wants to know what time he wakes up and what he eats for breakfast, like the oatmeal closed the deal. We rarely look that closely at the people who did a lot of the same things and still lost.

I didn't understand any of that in eleventh grade. I took a job at a retail store, and for the first time I had my own money. Nobody hands out trophies at the register, but they do hand out a paycheck. Baseball became something I used to do. Years later, I was teaching, coaching, building businesses, raising sons, and losing things that cost a lot more than a baseball season, and I kept coming back to that same basic question. What does a loss actually prove? Sometimes quite a bit, and sometimes almost nothing.

That difference matters because of what we tend to do next. When people care about you, they want to make your pain useful, and they want it fast. They say, "Everything happens for a reason," or "God has something better," or "This is making you stronger," or "Keep your head up." I get it, because I've said those things myself, usually when I didn't know what else to say.

I'm a Christian, and I believe God can use things I would never have chosen. I also don't think my faith asks me to pretend I understand why every painful thing happened. Some things in my life became useful later. Some losses sent me in a new direction, and some things that broke down eventually became material for something else. I can see that now because enough time has passed. But I don't believe every bad thing is fertilizer and we're supposed to keep digging until we find the flower. Sometimes we don't know. Sometimes

the only honest sentence available is, *I hate that this happened.* I've gotten more comfortable with that.

What concerns me more is what we do when we skip understanding the loss and go straight to fixing ourselves. If somebody beat you because they were better, getting better makes sense. If the loss came down to something close to random, that calls for a different conversation. If something was taken from you, searching forever for your own failure can turn into punishment. If you've been winning the wrong game, working harder can carry you further from the life you actually want. And if you walked away because staying had gotten too expensive, calling yourself a quitter may miss the whole decision.

Those are different losses. I didn't know that when I was seventeen. I knew one thing, and it was to get back up. I'm grateful my father taught me that, and it's carried me through some hard seasons. Learning when to keep moving, and where to point that effort, took me a lot longer.

KEEP READING

That was one kind of loss. There are five.

The rest of *The Pink Lemon* sorts them out:

1. Somebody beat you
2. The margin was almost random
3. Something was taken
4. You were playing the wrong game
5. You walked out

Each one asks for a different response.

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